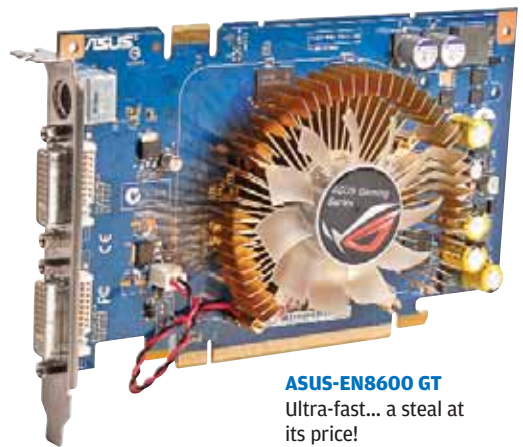


| Decision Maker                                               |                      |                                             |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| You Want                                                     | Suggested Chipset(s) | We Recommend                                |
| ▶ The best gaming card, price no bar                         | 8800GTX / Ultra      | Galaxy 8800Ultra, XFX PV-T80F-SHE9          |
| ▶ A powerful DX 10 card; budget under Rs 25,000              | 8800GTS              | MSI NX8800GTS 320                           |
| ▶ A good gaming card; budget Rs 15,000                       | X1900XTX, X1950XTX   | ASUS EAX1900XTX, GeCube GC-HV195XTG3-E3     |
| ▶ The best value for money card; budget Rs 10,000            | 8600GT/GTS           | ASUS EN8600GT, Foxconn 8600GTS              |
| ▶ A cheap gaming solution; budget Rs 5,000                   | 8500GT               | Sparkle 8500GT 256 MB                       |
| ▶ An HTPC / Multimedia PC solution, budget Rs 2,000 to 3,000 | 8400GS               | Sparkle GF PCX-8400GS 256 MB, Galaxy 8400GS |

offerings—meaning if one removes the DX 10 equation from the picture the X1900/X1950 cards offer terrific value for money at their current prices.

If you want something powerful enough for all DX 9 games at decent settings and resolutions, and if you're on a frugal budget, we suggest ASUS' EAX1900XTX, at Rs 9,900. Just remember you aren't DX 10 ready with this one...

This time there's no reward for second place... Why? Well, there are two winners. With a fraction of a point between them, ASUS' EN8800GTX Aquatank and Galaxy's 8800 Ultra share our Best Buy Gold award. In you're looking for the most powerful card out there, and cash happens to be bountiful, go for Galaxy's 8800 Ultra. Just make sure you have a good 500-watt power supply, else your gaming rig will go up in smoke! Although ASUS' EN8800GTX Aquatank is definitely fast, it's also super-expensive, and very difficult to find. Unless you specifically want liquid cooling—we don't see why you would—we suggest you stick with the Galaxy 8800Ultra, or



**ASUS-EN8600 GT**  
Ultra-fast... a steal at its price!

at higher resolutions will cause all available cards to stutter. This game rewards lots of shader units, memory bandwidth and quantity.

**Company of Heroes:** As an RTS, *Company of Heroes* is a delightful-looking game. What is shocking is that it looks even better up close—as good as any third person shooter around. Weapon detailing, damage effects, and squad and vehicle animations are absolutely top-notch.

**Splinter Cell: Chaos Theory:** Featuring ultra-realistic lighting and shadow detailing as well as incredibly well rendered locales, *Chaos Theory* is one of the oldest games in this test. It nonetheless still has what it takes to bring the latest cards to their knees. This game exemplifies what DX 9 and SM 3 are really capable of.

**Far Cry:** With huge outdoor levels, complete with the Pixel Shading goodness that brings the environments in the game to life *Far Cry* set the benchmark for the way games should look and play way back in 2004. Three years down the line, *Far Cry* is still a very good looking game.

#### REAL-WORLD: OPENGL-BASED

**Serious Sam 2:** Like its predecessor, *Serious Sam 2* features sprawling outdoor levels, with tons of bad guys to shoot at. Although this engine is largely CPU-bound, it still makes a very

good test for the slower mid-range and entry-level solutions.

**Prey:** Based on a heavily modified and optimised *Doom 3* engine, *Prey* is significantly heavier on system resources than its ancestor was. Level design is excellent, and with great use of lighting and physics, not to mention superb gameplay, *Prey* is a definite must for gamers and benchmarks alike.

**Doom 3:** The only other “old” game apart from *Far Cry*, *Doom 3* nonetheless still has what it takes to mash the lower-end crop of cards. The fact that the engine is so sensitive to even minor changes in hardware makes it the perfect engine for benchmarking. The engine still has one of the best implementation of shadows we've seen—and level design is superbly scary and unbelievably claustrophobic.

#### SYNTHETIC BENCHMARKS

**3D Mark 2006 Professional:** An industry-standard reference for Shader performance. 3D Mark is very taxing for entry level cards though most of the mid-range DX 10 cards can handle it easily.

**3D Mark 2005:** An older standard than 3D Mark 2006, this benchmark is nonetheless an industry standard, and proves the first challenge for entry-level cards, sort of like the beginners' difficulty level in a game.